

U8 small-squad session · 60 minutes

Five or six players (eight-player option). Focus: close control, finding space, deciding to dribble or pass. Timings include explanations, drinks and resets.

Before children arrive

Size 3 ball each + two spares; 16 flat cones; two-colour bibs; watch; water. Start with a 20 × 15 m training area, six 1 m gates and four cone goals. Check surface, footwear, covered shin pads, supervision and emergency arrangements.

0–8 · Arrival and ball warm-up

One ball each. Dribble, turn and stop. Gentle changes of speed; no laps or elimination.

8–20 · Find a different gate

Everyone dribbles. Three short rounds; find a free gate. Widen gates or space if crowded.

20–23 · Drink and demonstrate

Check comfort. Show the next game briefly; water is available throughout.

23–35 · Keep it or share it

6: three pairs. 5: pair + trio. 8: four pairs. Pass or dribble through gates. Last 4 min optional opposition: 6 = two 2v1; 5 = 2v2 + helper; 8 = two 2v2. Rotate roles each minute.

35–38 · Drink and reset

Keep four cone goals. Put spare balls with coach; supervise both areas if splitting.

38–55 · Short games

5: 2v2 + rotating helper on team in possession. 6: 3v3. 8: two 2v2 games with adult support. Short bouts with recovery and role changes. Dribble through goals to score.

55–60 · Slow finish and reflect

Gentle dribbling/walking. Ask: Where did you find space? Collect kit; agreed handover.

Cues: little touches in traffic; look for a free gate; move after passing. Shorten or simplify for fatigue, cold, distress or confusion. Stop for injury. No heading, fitness punishments or forced repeated sprints.

Original editorial training plan, not FA-endorsed or field-tested with your group. England U7 match format is 3v3; U8 is 5v5 (2026/27). Suggested areas/timings are not match requirements. Full source notes and adaptations on the webpage.